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Harold Mabern

Pianist Harold Mabern was born in Memphis, Tennessee on March 20, 1936. He has shared the stage and studio with J.J. Johnson, Frank Strozier, Joe Williams and numerous others. Harold has enjoyed a long tenure as an instructor at William Paterson University and he records frequently with saxophonist Eric Alexander, one of his notable students.

Harold was interviewed at Hamilton College on March 31, 2010 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am very pleased to have pianist Harold Mabern with me today for the Jazz Archive. Welcome to Hamilton.

HM: Thank you.

MR: It's been a real pleasure listening to your numerous stories the last couple of days.

HM: Oh boy.

MR: You are not a shy man.

HM: Well you know I try not to be.

MR: I'm wondering if you were an outgoing kid?

HM: You know strangely enough I was very shy. Believe it or not I was very quiet, very shy. But as I got a little older I got a little more, how do you put it, outgoing and aggressive in my manner so to speak, when I moved to Chicago. But during the time I was in Memphis, Tennessee I was really a quiet, shy kid you know.

MR: I'm wondering, you know, we think of Memphis as a heavy blues town.

HM: Right.

MR: Did you hear blues a lot growing up in the home?

HM: We heard it in the home, and when I started getting into music, which was around the age of 15 or 16, see I'm a late bloomer, you know because being a self-taught musician I never took piano lessons. We had to play the blues because that was the way it was. And we were drugged and we were disappointed because we wanted to play bebop. And the club owners would say no, no, you've got to get that bebop out of here, you're running my customers out of here, in other words we had to play music that they could dance to. So what we did and when I say we I'm speaking of a lot about George Coleman's brother, who was a very good alto saxophonist. I played along with George Coleman's brother before I played with George Coleman. George Coleman's brother, Lucius Coleman, Louis Smith, a drummer named Big Moe, and that was it because we didn't have but two or three bass players, and Jamil Nasser was one. He was out with B.B. King. So most times the piano players had to walk the bass line. So what we would do,

we would play the blues, say "The Hucklebuck," which you later found out was "Now's The Time," but it's really "The Hucklebuck," Paul Williams "Hucklebuck" [scats]. So we would tell the drummer, you know, keep the backbeat while the people would dance. And then, once we got them dancing, we started playing the chord changes to "All the Things You Are," or "Perdido." That's how we got over. And the club owner would walk over and say, "That's much better, that's what I'm talking about." He never knew the difference, as long as the drummer, you know, kept the backbeat going. But like I say we were drugged because we says man we got to play these blues, but now, some 30, 40, 50 years later we realize what a blessing in disguise it was because everybody can't play the blues. Charles Mingus said, "I want to write like Duke Ellington and play the blues." The great Dizzy Gillespie, the coprogenetist of this music said "the difference between me and Bird is that Bird can play the blues and I couldn't. And that's what Dizzy said on videotape, which we knew that. I mean everybody can't play — it's something that you can't teach. That's the phenomenal thing about Eric Alexander as he was saying earlier. There are benefits of all jobs. He learned how to play the blues by being with Charles Earland, an association. And that's how that came about. We never talked about that, like Eric I'm going to teach you how to play the blues, because I can't because if I could teach somebody how to play the blues I would have gone to Gene Harris and said hey Gene, see because he could play the blues you see.

MR: Well let me ask you about this Memphis, the clubs. How old were you when you started doing that?

HM: About 15-1/2 or 16 years old.

MR: Okay. How did your parents feel about you playing in these dance clubs?

HM: Well they didn't have a problem with it, I guess they were just happy to see me try and pursue something rather than being in the streets, even though the streets, being in the streets then was nothing like it is now as far as what the young kids are doing. The things they do now we didn't even think about doing stuff like that. So they were always supportive of me because, like I say, they loved the blues, and we went to church, I had to go to church all the time, two or three times on a Sunday you know. But they always, you know, supported me. Because even though my mother was around, she and my father had separated for a while so I was raised up with my father, my aunt and my grandmother. But I still had a chance to be with my mother during that time.

MR: But you had this interest in bebop, and where did that come from at that age? Was it by the radio or buying LPs?

HM: No, see that's the thing. On the radio you didn't hear no — first of all, on the radio you would hear maybe some Dave Brubeck and some George Shearing, but you didn't really hear no Art Tatum, Charlie Parker, Bud Powell, at that time because that was too strong

for the airways. So even then, the artists who played that way had to play in a more commercial-type vein. But we always had big bands that would come to Memphis, like the Count Basie big band, or the Duke Ellington big band, or the Lionel Hampton Orchestra and they would play it at the Palace Theater and on that group would be like a big band, a jazz vocalist, maybe Sarah Vaughan or Ella Fitzgerald or something like that, and a comedian, and that would be it. So we had a chance to hear it that way. Otherwise we would just, some of the guys were hip enough to have had the records by Bud Powell and Charlie Parker and we used to go by their houses and listen. That's how we got exposed to it. But strange enough George Coleman and Louis Smith and Phineas Newborn, they already were hip to Charlie Parker, the hard edge, hard core, bebop if you will.

MR: I see. Were the clubs segregated at that time?

HM: Yes. The clubs were segregated at the time but there were a couple of artists [who] would be able to come in, but for the most part all the clubs were segregated, yeah.

MR: And this would have been around 19 —

HM: 1950, '51, '52 and on up, yeah.

MR: So your repertoire of blues would include tunes like "The Hucklebuck."

HM: "The Hucklebuck,"

MR: "Night Train."

HM: "Night Train," "The Boogie Woogie," a lot of slow blues with the singing, with the vocalist singing and stuff like that.

MR: What were the pianos like that you got to play on?

HM: Very bad. I mean really bad. See you know I think that probably most of the great piano players that would want to came up. Art Tatum played on bad pianos. Phineas Newborn Jr. had two pianos, both of them were bad. So there were no Steinways during that time. As a matter of fact they were all uprights. Very bad, keys missing, ivories jagged so if you're not careful you'd cut your finger. Oh that was some bad times. But we had to deal with what we had. And a lot of times the pianos would be so out of tune, that's how I think I learned how to transpose. I'd have to do crossover and I'd have to play in one key while they played in another key to match the sound.

MR: I'll be darned.

HM: So I think that's how I began to learn how to transpose. Because I had to do it back then.

MR: Well, almost like a guitar had a capo on it or something.

HM: Right. What they call a bar. You slide that bar down there, yeah, that kind of thing, yeah.

MR: That's interesting. So was there any mixing between the white and the black musicians at this time?

HM: Very, very little. Yes. I really can't call it integrated, no, 'cause like I said because it was before the total segregation. But what we would do, we could go to places like West Memphis, Arkansas, which was like across the bridge from us, and we would play in the white-owned club for the white audience, but it was totally segregated.

MR: Interesting. Well you said something about going to Chicago because you thought you were going to get into —

HM: Right. See when I graduated, [s/l] Frank Rhodes and I graduated from high school in 1954, so my sister and my brother-in-law and my mother were living in Chicago at the time. So she said well you come here and we'll try to send you to the Chicago Conservatory of Music. Because I had about three or four scholarships, one to Tennessee State, Arkansas State, Jackson College and some other place. But I turned them down because I wanted to be able to get to Chicago which was a larger city and a better environment musically speaking. But when I got there the money situation was not what it could have been so my sister said well look, we can't afford the college but since you're here just stay here and see what you can do, which is what I did. I stayed there and hung out in the streets of Chicago and went to all the clubs, made the rounds and made all the jam sessions and I just said the rest is history you know.

MR: Did you have music scholarships to these places?

HM: Yeah I had music scholarships. Because see I played in the high school band. I played baritone horn in the high school band. I played the marches, "Colonel Bogie" marches, "Washington Post" and all that stuff. So I had a scholarship based on that. And at that time I was playing very little piano because I couldn't, but most of it was because of my so-called expertise in the marching band.

MR: Okay, but your piano playing was and is mostly self-taught.

HM: All self-taught. All self-taught. As a matter of fact I went to the Chicago Conservatory and I went down, and I took a couple of lessons, but what it was was a case where I was memorizing the music. You probably heard this before from different people. It was like I was memorizing the music quicker than I could — like I'd look at it and say "The Happy Farmer" [scats] so I'd kind of like look at it and kind of pick it out. But then the next lesson it was like I had it memorized. I'd heard it by other people. But as far as formal training, no, I never really had any.

MR: So when you were presented with the, let's say someone that you were listening to was playing some kind of chord and you'd go oh man, what is that.

HM: Right.

MR: How do you go about finding out what that is?

HM: Well before I left, the band director, George Coleman, George Coleman knows a lot about chords, they would show me. I knew after I started playing I began to understand,

oh well this is a G minor to C seven, like that. So I was kind of getting a little handle on it there. And then I could read, we had a little fake book called "The Warren's Black Chord Book," it was about that wide and that high, and all it had in there if it would have "Body and Soul" it would have E flat. Now you had to figure out E flat minor, E flat major, E flat what. But no melody notes or nothing. So we'd use that for certain tunes. But then once I got to Chicago, that's when my ear training kind of opened and I really started to get down with chords and everything. So I never did really have a problem reading the chord changes once I saw what it was, but formal training, I didn't have any of that. But the environment in Chicago was so healthy and so vast because here in Memphis you'd have maybe one or two great piano players. But in Chicago you might have five or six on every corner that could play. Because the city was a larger city, naturally.

MR: Did you do any of the blues gigs on the south side or was that not something you pursued?

HM: No. Well strange enough, I worked a lot in a big band on the south side with the Morris Ellis Big Band. He was the wonderful trombonist that went to school at Howard University with Benny Golson and Eddie Jones. He used to play up in Count Basie's band. And so that's how I got my little bit of big band training, by playing in a big band. And the charts were kind of, you know for somebody self-taught, they weren't really too easy, but I was able to hang in there and get the experience that I needed. And after that when I moved to New York I was able to get right in Lionel Hampton's band. So the experience I had in Chicago was good for me to play the music in Hamp's band because I'd been reading music, you know, in the big band in Chicago.

MR: Yeah. What was the pay scale back in Chicago in those days. What kind of money would you make on a gig?

HM: Well if you made, say if you made 45 dollars on a weekend, that was a lot of money. If you made a gig, like a private party where you made 75 or a 100 dollars, oh man, that was fantastic. But I would say the basic pay would be something like 45 dollars per night. And what I would do is I would get that 45 dollars and go straight to Citibank, if I must say, not that I'm pushing them, and put it in, and I saved up. So when it was time for me to make my move to New York City I had the money already saved up.

MR: Oh. That's thinking ahead. But New York was like, okay, we have to go there.

HM: Yeah, you've got to go because you go to play, say in Chicago, you've got to know when to make your move. After you say well we've done everything we can do here, it's time to make the move to the Big Apple. Now see New York City, you never make the move because you're never not there because there's things to be done, even now, I mean just the city itself. But no matter what town you're in, you can be in L.A. or Memphis or Chattanooga, whatever. There comes a time when you say, well we've gone as far as we

can go because we had a good group in Chicago called the MJT + 3, young people. Frank Strozier, Bob Cranshaw, Walter Perkins, myself, Bobby Bryant, you know. And we were very successful during that time. There were three groups that had hit records: Ahmad Jamal Trio, Ramsey Lewis Trio, and our group, you know. But after the work kind of subsided we said okay, it's time to make the move to New York, which is what we did, because when we went to New York we had work lined up. We didn't go there just to be checking it. We already had at least six to eight weeks' work lined up, in and around the New York area.

MR: You're talking about—

HM: MJT + 3.

MR: Okay. Did that require that you have some kind of agent or something?

HM: Well we had some kind of little agent. Sarah Vaughan, one of Sarah Vaughan's husbands, he was kind of managing us. He was more of a manager than an agent I guess it's one entity, you know.

MR: Well what was New York like for you the first time that you got there?

HM: Oh, overwhelming. I couldn't believe it. Even though I had read about it and seen pictures, but I couldn't believe what I could hear, really, for all intents and purposes by myself, but even George Coleman was there and Booker Little because at that time, they were working with Max Roach's group. But as far as family members, I was on my own. And I said at that point, you know, I was mature enough to know how to handle it and everything. I knew how to manage whatever little money I had, and not go through it. And the thing was, we wanted to be in New York at least six months, which was the requirement, that you had to be there to get your union card. So before you could get your union card you'd be considered like a traveling musician, even though you're in New York. And when the union man comes out you'd have to have like a thing to say, well I'm a traveling musician and I'm trying to establish residency here so I can eventually get my union card, which is what I finally did.

MR: And you could still play?

HM: You could still play.

MR: Until you got the card.

HM: Until you got the card.

MR: Yeah. The union was pretty strong back then wasn't it?

HM: Oh yeah. They would come around and check your union card. It's not quite like that now but during that time, oh, they would come around, "Okay young man let me see your union card." Now if you come and tell them I don't have one or something, what do you mean you don't — you know what I mean? Oh yeah, they were very — I don't think they do that as much now as they used to. And then they'd say we want you at the union hall

Monday morning at eight o'clock, and you'd have to come and explain why you didn't have a union card.

MR: Wow. And when you finally were able to get in, did you have to do any auditioning for them?

HM: Not really. The only requirement was that okay, you want to join the union, you've been here six months or whatever it is, now you've got to have the amount of money it takes to join the union, which was, maybe during that time, I don't know it might have been 50 or 75 or 100 dollars, which was a lot of money during that time. Now I'm sure it's much, much more and the requirements are stronger. I don't think you have to do an audition but there are certain things that are stronger.

MR: So you start to get established, and what was the Lionel Hampton gig like for you?

HM: Very interesting. What happened, I got to New York and as I was telling a couple of students today, they wanted to know how did I motivate myself and get ahead. I said go to all the jam sessions. Even if it's not a jam session, if you go to hear somebody play and you feel you're sure you can play, try to do that. So Lionel Hampton was working at a place called the Metropole Lounge, on Seventh Avenue around 47, 48th street. And he wasn't using a piano player. You know he was using guitar. Bill Maker was playing guitar

MR: Who was that?

HM: So one of my dearest friends from Chicago named John Neeley, rest his soul, he said why don't you come by and sit in with Gates we called him. Lionel Hampton called him, "Hey Gates, come on Gates." You know. So I went by and he introduced me to — and the Metropole was like a long bar, it was long and the band was spread out. You know it wasn't too wide, just long. So John Neeley introduced me and said, "Hey this is Harold Mabern, he's from Chicago, can he sit in?" And he said, "Yeah, Gates, you want to play something?" So I got up there, and naturally I knew "Flying Home" from the get go. And because I had been reading music in the big band in Chicago, my eyes were kind of up. And Hamp's music wasn't that extreme, it was mostly chords, not a lot of notes, maybe a little passage here. So I sat in and he said, "Yeah, Gates, yeah Gates, I like you" he said, "yeah, Gates, you want to go to Argentina with me?" I said yeah, you know, I didn't even know if I had a passport then. So he said, "Okay Gates, you've got to come down here Thursday and the doctor will be here to give you vaccinations, you know, and you go down and get your passport. During that time you could go to the passport office at Rockefeller Center, you know, like 49th and what was it, Fifth Avenue. So I got my passport. Now one of Hamp's agents, he was booked by Joe Glaser. And the tickets were already bought for the plane flight. So I think, some kind of way, I took somebody else's seat. I don't know who, you know. He said, "Yeah Gates." So I got there, got my

vaccinations on that Thursday, that Friday I was on my way to Buenos Aires Argentina, and that's how that happened. So I stayed with the band for a whole year, because, like I said, but at some point I was getting a little tired because I wanted to really play, that's why I was in New York. I said a big band was one thing but I'm not getting that many solos. Then when I would get a solo, Hamp would come and start playing two fingers at the top so I was really getting a little tired of that. So we did about a six week tour, all through Europe, everywhere. All one nighters, oh man, all one nighters. You know. And what we when we would do a gig, even over there, we would find a place to go jam. They called them hot clubs. And we played tunes like "Straight Street," John Coltrane's "Straight Street" and stuff like that. And we would tell Hamp and he'd say, "Hey Gates, you all hanging out tonight?" And we'd say, "Oh no, we're not hanging out tonight because we'd have Hamp hanging around." He would get up there and want to play the same songs he'd been playing and come back and do the two piano thing. So when we got back to the States I was living in the Sloan House Y, which was good because I was only paying zero point 75 cents a day. Could you imagine that?

MR: Say that again?

HM: Zero point 75 cents a day.

MR: What was the name of the place?

HM: The Sloan House YMCA. 34th Street between Eighth and Ninth Avenue. Because I had five thousand dollars when I got there. In 1959 five thousand dollars was probably like what, 20 or 30 thousand dollars, because the cost of living was down. I mean Transcontinental Airlines from New York to Chicago by [Inaudible] was 24 dollars and 50 cents. The Four Seasons, the Sheraton, the Waldorf was like 50 dollars a week. You go there now, the occupancy rate is 65 dollars a night. That's aside from the 300 or 499 dollars, you know. So five thousand dollars was a lot of money. Five thousand dollars is a lot of money now. If somebody just said I'm going to give you five thousand dollars for a piano lesson or a half hour gig, you know. So but I said I'm going to hold on to this money. How can I stretch it? Because we were staying at a hotel in midtown Manhattan called the Flanders. A lot of musicians stayed there. And I think that was something like 10 or 15 dollars a week. But I said I've got to make this money — because once this money goes if I don't preserve it and get some gigs I'm going to be back in Chicago and I had no intention of doing that. So somebody told me about the Y. And I went there and I said okay, I can handle this. Private rooms you know. But you had to go to go to the main bathroom to take a shower. They had a lot of face bowls and stuff, it was big and roomy but you had to pick your time to get your showers in, for your privacy. So then I said but at this point I saved my money and I said I'm going to get an apartment. So I was able to get an apartment on 130 West 73rd Street, like a one-room kitchenette, it was 96 dollars a

month, which wasn't bad. Now I'm sure that same place — I go by there sometimes and look at the building — I'm sure that place probably rents for five thousand dollars a month. The same place. So I said I need a phone, so I called the phone company. First thing, "Do you have any references?" I said, "Yeah I play with Lionel Hampton's Orchestra. They checked it out, telephone, no problem. So the gig worked that way. So now we're getting ready to go to Wildwood, New Jersey. So Cedar Walton, one of my dearest friends, called and said, "Brother Mabern, we're down here at Birdland with the Jazztet, you know, Art Farmer, Benny Golson, Cedar Walton, Tootie Heath and probably Tommy Williams on bass. And he says, "You might want to come and sit in" you know. And I took him on. Because I was only one stop from Birdland on the subway, you know, where I lived. So I went down and Cedar introduced me to Benny Golson. But Benny Golson and Art, they kind of knew me from Chicago anyway with the MJT + 3. So I sat in and I don't know what we played, something kind of like here, it might have been a blues, but I started playing. See I've always loved to comp. That's my passion. You know I tell people I'm more concerned about being a great comper than a great soloist, because if I comp good then I feel I have a chance to get more jobs. So I started comping and I look up and I see Benny Golson smiling you know. And Art Farmer never did show much emotion. He had his horn out here and Tommy McIntosh, yeah, he was smiling. So when he got through playing and Benny Golson said, "Yeah Mabern, man, yeah, wow." Whatever. And Art Farmer said, "Hey man, Benny and I we really didn't" — you know because they were very unhappy because Cedar Walton was getting ready to leave to go with Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers. Cedar Walton, Reggie Workman, Freddie Hubbard and Curtis Fuller went with that group. See that's the thing in New York even then. Gigs were turning over. And if you happened to be in the right place you could get a gig if you could halfway play. The cat would say, "You want to sit in?" And if you could halfway play and swing, and I was always a good comper, a pretty good comper, and whatever little solo I played it swung, because I listened a lot to Wynton Kelly, one of my heroes you know. So I sat in so Art Farmer said, "Hey man, we're getting ready to make a change and we got somebody kind of but if we hear anything we'll let you know." I said, "Okay, I'm going on back home to my apartment, because I'm going to Wildwood, New Jersey the next morning." So around eight o'clock in the morning the telephone rings. I said, "Hello?" He said, "Yes, this is Art Farmer." I said, "Yes." I thought why is he calling me? He said, "Benny and I talked it over and we want you to join the band." Just on the way I was comping. I'm not bragging but that's all it was, the way I was comping and supporting them. So I said, "Well how do you want me to play?" And so Art says, "Just the way you did last night." So at this time Benny Golson writes hard music. There are certain people that write music that write hard with a purpose: Thad

Jones, Frank Foster, Benny Golson, Slide Hampton. You know, certain ones, if I've got to play some of that music, get it to me ten weeks ahead of time, you know. So I told Art, I said, "Well you know Art, you know you're playing all those hard piano parts." So Benny said, "Don't worry, Mabern, we're kind of getting away from that." Because this time, this would have been the third Jazztet from the original with McCoy Tyner. Then Cedar. Now I'm coming it and that's the third Jazztet. So sure enough they cut back on some but I still had certain kinds of music to read. So then I got in the band so Lionel Hampton says, "Gates, I'm going to take you to court, I'm going to sue you, I told you to stay with me, I was going to make you big as bubble gum." That was his saying, you know. But we kind of worked it out, you know, because by rights you're supposed to give two weeks notice and I think I gave five days notice or something. Because I said at this point I can not miss this gig. I mean this is a chance to really get out in the forefront. A band from New York, be on the scene, you know what I mean? Too good to be true, you know. So but we worked it out and he wished me well because at one point in time Benny Golson and Art Farmer had both been in his band, aside from Art Blakey, Lionel Hampton had more all-stars in his band than anybody had ever had: Clifford Brown, Gigi Gryce or Quincy Jones playing trumpet, Art Farmer, Alan Dawson or Johnny Griffin.

MR: Dexter Gordon.

HM: You name it. You know what I mean?

MR: Even Joe Wilder played with him.

HM: Everybody went through there. George Coleman was in there for a minute.

MR: Well wasn't that band, maybe not at the time, but considered to be sort of like a stopping point.

HM: Yeah.

MR: I'll be here for a while —

HM: For a while, right.

MR: Because he didn't pay great, did he?

HM: He didn't pay good. Well but let's face it though, but he paid what was the going rate during that time, because I know they'd give you money in this envelope and they'd have all the deductions. It was 165 a week. But after the 165 I was able to save a hundred dollars. You see what I'm saying? So that still was a lot of money. If I could save a hundred dollars a week, hey man, you kidding? So I'd take that 65 and stretch it and pay my little phone bill, maybe my phone bill might have been what ten or fifteen dollars a month? You know what I'm saying? So that was the going — it was 165.

MR: And were you still single at the time?

HM: I'm still single at the time, yeah. So then when I got with the Jazztet, that was, as a matter of fact there's a book out now that was put out by the Baroness Rothschild called

Musicians' Three Wishes. And she would go around with a camera and ask the musicians if they had three wishes what would that be. And come to find out I'm in the book. I never had no idea. I don't even recall her or anybody talking to me. Because see here again, I would go to hear Thelonious Monk I would sit at the table with the band but I was well reserved and I knew how to keep my mouth shut and not speak until I was spoken to. And see even then, the older musicians liked me because I wasn't one to run my mouth, like I knew, I would listen, and when they spoke to me. So I said, "Are you kidding?" and Michael West said, "Yeah Mabern, you're in that book." There's two beautiful pictures, one with me and Charlie Rouse and one with me and Teddy Wilson, another one of my heroes, you know. Shortly after that we went to the Lionel jazz festival and we left there and probably went to Chicago and that's where I met my wife, when I was with the Jazztet. And I used to say Benny Golson — then I thought about it and I said, now Benny Golson's on the spot. He's responsible for hiring me, but it was Cedar Walton that made it possible for me to sit in. So I said, "Cedar I've been with my wife almost fifty years, maybe because of you." He said, "Brother Mabern, I didn't know that." So that's how, and then I stayed with the band until it disbanded. I was with the band, we did two records together with the band and I did one beautiful quartet date with Art Farmer called "Perception" with Roy McCurdy, Tommy Williams and myself. A beautiful date. And like I always told Sonny [inaudible], he likes it, I said well, on any kind of job don't leave the job unless the job leaves you. That's my philosophy. As long as the job is going, don't leave the job. Why should I go looking for something that already — you know what I mean? So I never quit a job, I stayed until it was over then I moved on to the next gig.

MR: Would that band have gone under the heading of hard bop?

HM: Yeah I would say so because we were playing across things, because you know Benny did a lot of writing of his own. And to this day Benny Golson has never written a weak composition. Every composition that he has written is strong. "Stablemates?" Strong. Challenging. "Along Came Betty?" Strong. "Whisper Not?" Beautiful. "I Remember Clifford?" Beautiful. Most guys don't play that because a lot of guys don't know how to play just the melody because they don't know the difference between the melody in the first thing and secondly I mean it's very deceptive because Benny Golson is a true genius you know. And when he writes a composition it's a composition. It's not a song, it's a composition that's been thoroughly worked out and, you know what I mean. And creatively sound.

MR: Did you guys kind of have a separate half from the rock & roll and the pop music that was played on AM radio at the time? In other words, did you listen to the music that was getting all the airplay, the Chuck Berry and those guys? Did it affect you at all?

HM: If it was good music yeah. And to this day I still do that because see I always tell people — somebody asked me a question and I said well you know I consider myself a blues piano player that understands the philosophy of jazz. So I told Fred and he said, "You said that?" He said, "I like that." That's what I am. I'm going to always be, because blues or jazz comes from the blues. Because here again, like I said, not to be redundant, there are a lot of jazz musicians who can swing, who can play jazz, but they can't play the blues. You can't teach that. It's by nature or just being, or whatever. So that's the way I feel. I mean if I had a choice to play "Rakin' and Scrapin'" or one of my compositions or if somebody asks me, I'm going to take the blues because with me, the blues, I am the blues. Somebody else might say it, but I am the blues. That's me. And don't forget, I was working at the Half Note with Joe Williams, rest his soul, and Jimmy Witherspoon came down to see us. And Fred said — we were having a great time playing — so Spoon said, "Hey Joe, let me hear some blues." So Joe Williams said, "Spoon, it's too early for the blues." Spoon said, "Joe it ain't never too early for the blues." It's right. If you play with Milt Jackson you'd better know how to play the blues. That's what I said. Charles Mingus said, "I wish I could write like Duke Ellington and play the blues." So, so no, so I've always been attracted to the blues, even to this day, or anything that's bluesy. You know, like Ahmad Jamal played with George Hudson's Blues Band. That why if you listen to a lot of Ahmad's compositions they've got the bluesy feeling to it. Clifford Brown played with Chris Powell and the Blue Flames blues band, or Bill Hardman, played Tiny Bradshaw, Jimmy — you know, so most of those — Stanley Turrentine, Coltrane, played with — Earl Bostic Rhythm & Blues band. Now you've got Louis Jordan and the Tympany Five. George Coleman and Jimmy Anastos played with B.B. King's blues band, rhythm and blues. George Coleman took the first alto solo on "Woke Up This Morning" (my baby's gone), that was a hit, you see, so we all came up through the blues. No when I listen to the radio now, or whatever, anything that's bluesy or [inaudible] you know. I don't listen to everything because most of the stuff is not worth it because the minute you hear it you say well that's not my cup of tea. You can tell that it's nothing happening, you know. But like I was going to Denver one time. And I'm on American Airlines and I'm going to Denver for eight weeks by myself. Cold. I'm going to be like the house band. And you know how you listen to the headphones on the airplane and I hear [scats] I said what is that, it's so beautiful. Then it turned out to be Bobby Caldwell "What You Won't Do for Love" which to this day is a big hit all over Japan. So I'm always attracted to anything that's bluesy. Earth, Wind & Fire, Chaka Khan, whoever it is. If it's bluesy. I didn't listen like to like to Chuck Berry intentionally, but blues — Mulgrew Miller and I were talking about Little Milton Campbell and we were talking about B.B. B.B.'s great but Little Milton Campbell had some stuff together

and he was from Greenwood, Mississippi where Mulgrew Miller is from. Little Milton Campbell. He could sing "If Walls Could Talk" and "Poor Man Blues" you see. And see in Chicago you had to play the blues, not in New York City. You go on the south side of Chicago or the west side, and you had to know how to play some blues. And you had to know how to play for singers. And see those are the two foundations. So when I got to Chicago it was no big deal 'cause I already knew kind of how to play the blues from being in Memphis, Tennessee. Now what I get with the singers, now that becomes my accompanying skills. And those are the two things I think that have helped me as much as it can help me, is being able to play the blues, being able to swing, knowing chord changes, know how to transpose, and know how to play for singers.

MR: And how do you play for singers?

HM: Well the thing is you've got to know how to follow them, not lead them. One of the main things you do for singers — because most of the singers use the Great American Songbook — I hate to keep saying that but the Great American Songbook is the way of life, as I said before. If Art Tatum and Charlie Parker played it, who are we not to? Bird never wrote any — Bird wrote a couple of blues numbers [scats] and rhythm. Mostly everything that Charlie Parker played was "You and the Night and the Music" and "In the Still of the Night" or "April in Paris." They played standards. I'll tell you they played standards. Keith Jarrett's playing standards. Case closed you see. So to play for singers, the one thing I tell piano players, the one thing you don't do if you're playing for a singer, and the singer's singing [scats] if the singer is singing on the major sixth, [sings] "will I ever find" Sarah Vaughan. You don't voice the chord. You always try to voice the chord with the leading tone not being in the top part of the voice. Because if you do that then you're no longer accompanying. If you're playing the leading tone that she's singing, you orchestrate the way Nelson Riddle did with Frank Sinatra. See I think that, of myself as an orchestra because the piano is an orchestra. I play a little embellishment. That's how you play for a singer. Now some singers, Joe Williams loved the single line, like Count Basie. A note here and then a space. Ella Fitzgerald might like you to [scats]. Big band sound. Sarah Vaughan might like a combination of both you see. So you have to know how to do it with all of them and you do this by listening to them. So if you get a call for the gig already you know when to hold and when to fold. So it's really not that hard a thing. Then when you get an opening then you do your arpeggios or you do your big chord thing or whatever. And that's the thing. See that was the beautiful thing about playing for Joe Williams because anything I'd do he could follow me. I could never throw him off, because he could hear. You wouldn't throw him off. And then he'd sing behind the beat and I'd have to go straight ahead. I couldn't wait, because if I waited for him to try to — we're going to be wrong. Just follow the swallow, and keep doing what

you're doing, I'll meet you at the end you see. So that's really what I tell young piano players. Some of the greatest piano players I know are the ones the played for singers, like Tommy Flanagan, like Hank Jones, like Oscar Peterson. Oscar Peterson with Billie Holiday, great accompaniment. Oh yeah. Like Ellis Larkins. Like my hometown, who Hank Jones says is probably number one, Jimmy Jones, who did orchestrations for Duke, who played on that famous record with Sarah Vaughan with Clifford Brown or Joe Benjamin or Paul Quinichette and Herbie Mann. That's Jimmy Jones with those lush, beautiful chords. And see I've always been attracted to chords. I love chords you know. Plus I did a lot of listening to George Shearing who is one of my heroes. That's why I said harmonically speaking you know the people talk about Bill Evans but I've always been more involved with George Shearing's harmonic gestures, you know. And then there was a blind pianist who passed away named Chris Anderson from Chicago who was Charlie Parker's favorite piano player, who taught Herbie Hancock, because nobody really talks about it. I'm just here to tell you the truth. As a matter of fact I was told that Bill Evans used to come and check out Chris Anderson, which he did, because he was totally unique. He was a harmonic genius.

MR: What was his name?

HM: Chris Anderson. He said Herbie Hancock studied with him. A harmonic genius. And he came up with Bill Lee who was another genius, who was Spike Lee's father, that's the way I could put it, no people know about Bill Lee too much but he's Spike Lee's father. Harmonic genius. He was the one that taught me how to play music. Because when I heard him play in Chicago he was playing these chords and I said wow man, what kind of stuff is that? Now you had got away from Phineas playing, you know the two hands and swinging and orchestrating which is good, but when I heard these I call them harmonic gestures, I said man I've never heard no stuff like that. But see in Chicago, all piano players had their own harmonic devices. That's why, you know, and believe it or not it's still the most underrated city when it comes to musicians in jazz, if you can believe it, yeah. They're underrated. Well the people say what about the Memphis musicians? I say well we don't even count. They say wait a minute, what are you talking about. I say we were nonexistent. And it's the truth. But the musicians, but all the piano players in Chicago had certain harmonic devices. When I used to go to Richard Muhal Abrams' house, he had a certain way. He would play a straight ahead like Bud Powell. You know what I'm saying. But everybody had a harmonic concept. Floyd Morris, Ronnell Bright who was Nancy Wilson's accompanist. All the piano players that played. There was a legendary pianist there named Sonny Thompson who was like rhythm & blues, he could sit down and play like Art Tatum. You see what I'm saying? So that's how I learned, so when I Bill Lee playing all these beautiful harmonics I said man, I've got to find out what

that is. You know. So it took me two weeks before he would open up to me and he showed me, he talked to me about what he was doing, then he told me about Chris Anderson and Billy Wallace and naturally Mr. Ahmad Jamal was holding court at the Persian Lounge another harmonic genius, a true musical genius. I mean everybody knows how I feel about Ahmad and Phineas, that those are my two favorite piano players bar none, and they don't have a problem with it, you see what I'm saying. But back to about the singers, that's how you play for singers. You have to listen and let them sing and you become the orchestra. And see we used to listen to Nelson Riddle, Frank Sinatra in "The Wee Small Hours of the Morning." And when you listen to it you hear that it was a match made in heaven, the way Frank would sing and Nelson would, through his orchestration, he'd do strings and the violin and muted trumpets with the flute and the French horn, oh man. Nothing greater. And then when Herbie and I used to get together there was a great arranger and orchestrator, it was probably the greatest orchestrator that ever lived, his name was Robert Farnon. And he did some dates with J.J., he did a date with Joe Williams, "Here's to Life," and Herbie had records by him called the "Cross Five [inaudible] and Herbie and I used to listen to all those kind of things, and me being dumb I made a mistake and said, "Oh by the way, Herbie, I stealed your two Robert Farnon records." "Yeah man, give me my records." I should have kept my mouth shut. So but like I said Chicago was a harmonic town. You had singers like Lorez Alexander or Lurlean Hunter one of the greatest singers that Carmen McRae was in awe of. I think she's related to Clark Terry. Teri Thornton who played piano and sang, she got the I think the National Endowment one year and a couple of years later she was gone. So Chicago was a great city for that. Because you had to know how to play for singers, you have to know how to transpose, you had to play in all the keys, you had to play ballads. I played with Gene Ammons and you had to know how to play real slow. I played with Benny Carter — I did a gig with him called "Inside Benny Carter," one of the greatest records he's ever made. They didn't put the personnel on it but there's Roy McCurdy, Bob Cranshaw and yours truly. We rehearsed twelve hours a day for that date. It's called "Inside Benny Carter." I think they put it out on CD. So that's always been my thing you know. And when I got to New York, and like I say Hank Jones was scoping me out and I didn't even know it. And I played with all the singers at Birdland. Now don't ask me how it happened, I don't know. Maybe I played with one and word got around, and I'd be working opposite Coltrane. I played with Johnny Hartman way before McCoy and Trane. Johnny Hartman wouldn't leave home without me. I played with Arthur Prysock and I had to take off and I had Herbie Hancock to play Saturday night and Cedar Walter was there to confirm it. I had all the singers. I played with Ernestine Anderson, Etta James, Gloria Lynne, I mean we played "Watermelon Man" in A flat. I played with, like I say

Johnny Hartman, I played with Irene Reid, I had all the singing gigs from Birdland so consequently I was always on the scene. See it would be three bands. John Coltrane Quartet, Benny Carter Trio with Harold Mabern and Ron Carter and Roy McCurdy or Bill Lee and Roy McCurdy. Then I'd take a break then the Horace Silver Quintet. So that went on for years you know. So that really kind of tightened up my accompanying skills because I had expertise in playing for singers, and know how to treat this singer differently from that. If this singer was behind the beat and I felt I needed to pull her up I'd do something to enhance the beat, you know what I'm saying.

MR: Yeah. And you learned a lot of different keys, too, I would imagine.

HM: Yes, playing all the keys. Especially the female singers because say for example if they're singing "Lush Life," they're not singing in D flat it's too low. They've got to be singing maybe in the key of E, A or B. So you've got to really learn how to transpose. Oh yeah. You have to play in all the keys you know.

MR: Well I want to play something for you. I noticed the last couple of days you've got quite a musical memory for some of the things you've done. I tried to fool you or see if you could recognize something you did with Lee Morgan, and you got it right up. But this particular thing I don't think you'll —

[audio interlude]

MR: First of all, does it sound like somebody you know?

HM: Sounds very — I think you got me this time. It sounds very familiar. It almost sounds like me but —

MR: It is you.

HM: But I'm trying to —

MR: It's not something that was ever on a record.

HM: That's what I'm wondering about. Yeah. What is that? Oh that's Joe Williams. That's Joe. Yeah. I knew it sounded like me but I didn't recognize it. I said I didn't recall recording that on a record.

MR: Well this is you and Joe in about 1967 from the Rainbow Room.

HM: The Rainbow Room.

MR: In New York City.

HM: In New York City.

MR: And the reason I have this is because Joe apparently had someone record it.

HM: Right.

MR: And Jillean gave us all these tapes. And so this is like —

HM: Isn't that something, the Rainbow Room. We were probably up there for maybe sometimes we'd be up there maybe three or four or five weeks at a time. And Duke Ellington would come by because Joe loved Duke, you know. Duke loved to sing with

the maestro and I'd tell him go ahead and play something, he'd play. Jimmy Jones would come by. Because Joe loved Jimmy Jones. And he'd always tell me, he would say, you know, not necessarily play like Jimmy Jones but listen. Which I had no problem with that because Jimmy Jones and Jerome Richardson were the ones that recommended me for the job with Joe Williams, you know. But yeah, isn't that something. I think one time we played up there and Big Nick was the guest, and Joe Newman.

MR: That's — he's on this recording.

HM: Isn't that something. I knew it sounded like me but I didn't recall recording anything record-wise, that's why I had to listen to it yeah.

MR: Yeah. Well I'd love to find a record company who would be willing to put something like that out.

HM: That sure would be good for sure, yeah.

MR: You know I think Hugh Walker played on it.

HM: Hugh Walker, yeah, rest his soul.

MR: So that's pretty neat that you're here.

HM: Hugh Walker is one of those kind of drummers like he carried his own rhythm. He had his rhythm in his hip pocket. I mean the minute he sat down. He was on one of my favorite record dates "Rakin' and Scrapin'." Hugh Walker is on that. Hugh Walker, George Coleman, Blue Mitchell and Bill Lee. Yeah, Hugh Walker.

MR: Was there a period of, was there any particular period of time, a decade or whatever, that it got harder to make a living in the jazz world?

HM: Oh yeah.

MR: What was that for you?

HM: Oh well I can tell you precisely. I think, let me see now, it could have been around maybe close to '68, '67, '68. Things were getting a little tight so I would always say well it's no point in me waiting for the phone to ring so. So I said let me see what I can find. Now mind you playing music all my life I had no expertise in anything. I didn't have any college degree, I didn't know anything, auto mechanics, woodwork, no other skills. So I went to Alexander's Department Store and got the job. And I had my shirt and tie on and I guess they called me an Expediter, whatever that means, "May I help you," or, "How may I help you" and I worked that job, punched my clock, brought my little pay home. It wasn't a lot of money. And the minute that happened, that's when the phone rang and it was Lee Morgan, he said, "Hey man I've got this gig" wouldn't you know. So anytime things got a little tight I'd go to the day job then a jazz job would come through. So then I got the job with Lee and I think before that I worked a place called Fleet Messenger Service. I think my pay was, after taxes, thirty-six dollars, can you believe that? After taxes.

MR: Thirty-six.

HM: Thirty-six dollars.

MR: A week?

HM: After taxes. And this was before the bikes came in. I was a messenger. I was taking the subway and walking. Package was fifty cents then. Then my big job came after that, I worked with the *Wall Street Journal* I had two bags of newspapers. I'd get there at six o'clock in the morning and pack up my bags and so I was walking one day, I had two bags and I was going to the Pan Am building. And that was my last drop off. So that's why I love going there because I could just drop three hundred papers. So I'm walking around and I see the Judge, Milt Hinton, pushing his upright bass with his electric bass. Because you know during that time Milt Hinton and Richard Davis and all those people, they were on first call. George Duvivier. So he was shocked, he said "Judge, what are you doing?" I said, "Well Judge, I'm trying to take care of my family." So he didn't say well give me your number I've got something for you. He said, "Well a man's got to do what a man's got to do." And I didn't take it — I kept stepping. And then I kind of quit that job and started doing some other things. But then, before he passed, his lovely wife Mona, rest her soul, she told me she said, "You know I want to tell you something, that Milton always respected you." Because Milt Hinton went to the same high school my wife went to, Wendell Phillips, Nat Cole went there and Ruth Jones. Ruth Jones is down in Washington. She went there to Wendell Phillips. My wife went there, Lou Rawls, Sam Cooke, they all went to Wendell Phillips High School. But she told me, Mona Hinton, she said, "You know Milton always respected you and loved your playing," and she said he told her that when he saw you that day delivering [inaudible] he gained more respect." I said, "Well I appreciate it but I'm just doing what I have to do, I don't deserve no brownie points for that." So that's how that happened. So then a lot of musicians, I think McCoy Tyner drove a cab for a while and a lot of musicians — Ahmad Jamal had a day job even though he was working in Chicago. He was talking about it. Ahmad Jamal he worked with [inaudible] Scott, Izzy Carlson was a mailman. Izzy Carlson would come in in the morning and we had breakfast parties and play with us and Frank Strozier, and go finish his route. Vernell Fournier had a job at Chills. Ernie [inaudible] worked at the post office. Bob Cranshaw was a sanitation man. Hello? And I mean he wouldn't mind my saying it because it's the truth, that's right. So everybody had some kind of day job but the difference was they had a day job but they still had a music job at night. Me, I had to resort too because I didn't have a music job but whenever I took a day job then the music gigs would come in so to speak.

MR: How interesting.

HM: Yeah. Art Tatum I think worked at the library. He would play his gig. The gig was just a means to the end but the real music would come to the after night sessions. He would go for the sessions. I wasn't here but this is what I was told. Lucky Roberts played and jammed all night where they would cut heads and that naturally the baddest cat played last and then he would leave and go take a shower or whatever and go and do his regular job during the day at the library or something. So a whole lot of people had day jobs. That was a way of life then.

MR: What was the impact of the civil rights movement and then the civil rights bill in '64 or whatever. Did it make any difference in your life?

HM: To tell you the truth I can't say that it did really. The only thing it could have made a difference was that maybe hotel accommodations or something, but see I didn't really get caught up in that because the real troopers like the Dinah Washingtons and the Harry Belafonte and people like that, they were the ones who really suffered with that where they could work at a club in any city but they couldn't stay at the hotel where they worked, or they had to change their clothes in the bus or something. So I really kind of avoided it but I can't say that it enhanced my career one way of the other. But I've always been down for the cause naturally, right is right and wrong is wrong, you know. Because when I was in Memphis, Tennessee the buses I used to board you'd have to sit in the back of the bus. When we got on the bus even then, and we weren't trying to be militants we just knew that this is wrong. Here's all these seats here, I got to go to the back of the bus and maybe get a seat or stand up. So we would just sit there and they'd say — and this is no lie — he'd say "boy" (this was his exact words, and I'd say, you did say "Roy" didn't you) then he'd say, "Get in the back of the bus." And we would get up and go towards the back of the bus. But every day they would have to tell us to do it. We would just sit down. You know like the freedom fighter lady, you know what I'm talking about, I must be losing it I can't think of it off the top of my head.

MR: Me too. I do.

HM: But anyway that's the way it was. But I have great respect for all the people involved with it because all the people, all races, gave up a lot to make things better. That's why when I look at some of these young people out here acting like fools and dressing like clowns it bothers me that everything — here you've got a black president of the United States and you would think you would be so motivated but they're not. It's like they go on worse. You know it makes no sense. There's been a lot of people to give up things, their lives, to make it better for you to go to school, to get a scholarship, like you were saying, even the jazz students here. You've got a chance to go to school to learn how to play jazz. Even when I was going to high school jazz was halfway tolerated. "Oh that's enough of that jazz, let's play these marches." But now you can go to school to learn how

to play jazz and a lot of them don't even take advantage of that. It makes no sense you see what I'm saying. Oh Rosa Parks.

MR: Rosa Parks.

HM: But that's the way that is, but you know as things move on I always felt, and even then, since the beginning of Louis Armstrong, because nothing, definitely he was the forerunner, you've got to say that. And then I'll say Charlie Parker, check him out, Charlie Parker's okay. Now let me expand it. So Pops got it started, Bird got it cleaned up and changed everything. You know what I'm saying?

MR: Man you've had quite a career. And it's active now in the education part of it at William Paterson, it added a lot for you?

HM: Right. Yeah, it's been, because this sounds like a redundant statement but as Ted Dunbar used to say teaching is learning and learning is teaching and it's true. Because if you get students, especially if you've got students who can already play, and you show them something, then they say, "You mean do it like this?" And you say, "Wait a minute, what was that?" Yeah okay. I'll keep it for myself. So I teach but I also learn. Like I was saying earlier, I played this song, and I said, "Hey Eric, this is what Travis played." One of Eric's closest friends, Travis Shook. Wonderful piano player. And I was playing this song of mine and he did a voice of a chord so I still use that voicing that he showed me, all the time. You know Coltrane was like that. He played some stuff, he had some stuff he played where later on in his life he started playing [scats]. He got that from John Gilmore. Of course I was on Birdland on the night when he sat in when John Gilmore, and John Gilmore was sitting in with Pete LaRoca and Trane said, "Woo man" he said, "hey Pete, let John play" because Trane liked it [scats] and Trane put it in print on the next day, he said, "this is something I got from John Gilmore." I told him, John, that's the way Trane was. Some guys say well I've got my own thing and I got this, and I say, "No you don't. Everybody's got something from somebody." And then you take it and turn it around in a certain way. But no, the teaching area has been good for me because like I said before, I don't consider myself a teacher, I'm an advanced student. That's it. Because if you get to the point where you say I know it all, you're not going to grow. I want to continue to grow. I told Ahmad Jamal something once you know. I knew what he was going to say. I said, "Ahmad, you sound so good, you don't need to practice." He said "let me tell you something, Harold Mabern, everybody needs to practice." And he's right. And I knew what he was going to say I just wanted — and if he's at home now he's got two Steinway D's up there you see. And so that's why he's Ahmad Jamal because he's not wasting any time. He's constantly improving and writing more beautiful songs and sounding better on that piano you know.

MR: Let me run a couple of names by you and just get your impression of these musicians. One is Cannonball Adderley.

HM: Tremendous respect. Loved him. Tremendous talent. Great, great musician. Great, great man. And you know the thing I learned from him? Somebody asked him once, said, "Mr. Adderley," they said, "do you consider yourself a great or big man?" And Cannonball said to him, "Well a big man is judged by someone other than one's self." Hey, Hello? I mean a lot of people could say the same thing. Hello? See that's another Virgo. I have tremendous respect for Cannonball Adderley, and his brother. You see what I'm saying. As a musician and as a human being. Well articulated you know. I heard him talking about something, "Ladies and Gentlemen we have this composition here written by James Heath, you know him as Jimmy Heath, and it's called 'Gemini' and we're going to pursue to endeavor all the parts." I said, "Go ahead, Cannon." He said, "We just got an article in this newspaper called *All About Jazz*" — and he's talking about, Cannonball was an intelligent man, I mean he was smart man. Plus he made Coltrane good. You listen to those records, Cannonball didn't back up for nobody. And he was studying. One day Jimmy Anessis said he saw Cannon, he said, "Hey Cannon" he said, "I'm sorry man I gotta run, I got a saxophone lesson." He was going to take a lesson with Marshall Royal.

MR: No kidding.

HM: That's how you get better. You never stop growing, you never stop listening, you never stop learning. You know like I was thinking about the trumpet players. I said they can listen to anybody but the one trumpet player, say other than say Clark, Joe Wilder or Snooky, all the trumpet players I don't care who you are to this day should be hanging out with Jon Faddis to get the Dizzy Gillespie system. See that's who they should be checking out. Jon Faddis. Because for me Dizzy still, if there is a king on the trumpet I still got to give Dizzy the edge. Sorry. That's the way I feel about it. John Birks, you know? Hey man, you know?

MR: Well you did the thing with Miles.

HM: Right.

MR: In '63.

HM: In '63, before Herbie Hancock. Only a few people know about that. April 1963. And we had a great time too. See here again, Miles used to be from Chicago with them, 'cause I've never pursued a gig, see I never called up a guy and said, "Hey man, give me a gig," because that's never been my thing, even before I could put two notes together I always said that if you could play, if you've got, somebody will hear. So when I went out of town I was out with Roy Haynes' quartet. Roy Haynes, Larry Wood Ridley, Frank Strozier. So I came back. So I'd been on staff. So I said well let me get these two weeks I

got at Birdland. So somebody called and said, "You ain't got no two weeks." So I got up and my wife said, "Oh by the way call Betty Carter, she's got two weeks for you at Birdland." I was just, it was maybe five years, I don't know. So she said also, "Do you know somebody named Prophet?" Well Prophet, his name was Richard Jennings, he was a well talented artist, he could draw pictures and paintings with birds, and Miles loved him and everybody knew him. And he knew I could comp. And Joe Griffin knew I could comp. So I called Prophet and he said, "Call Miles, Miles is getting ready to start a new band because the present band he had had just broken up, which was Wynton Kelly, Paul Chambers, J.J., Sonny Stitt was in Philadelphia, and that was the last gig. So Miles had this west coast trip. So I called him up and I said, "Hey Miles, it's Harold." [whispers] "How you doin' man?" He knew who I was, "What's happening?" I said, "Nothing, what's goin' on?" "I got this little tour, I want to see if you want to make it." I said, "well yeah I'd like to" so I said — he said, "well what you doin?" I said, "I'm down at Birdland with Betty Carter Saturday night." "I'll be by." I said, "What's the money talking about?" I know what the going rate then, 'cause I knew Cannonball was paying two-fifty. That was a lot of money. I said, "What's the money talking about?" "What you want?" I said, "Can I get two-fifty?" "You got it." But even then, before he was going to really hire me, he wanted to check me out just to be sure. And he said he had called everybody but me and another piano player, and I won't call his name out of respect, and I was next to the last on the list on the list. I didn't have no problem with that. Hey I don't — because you know during that time I wasn't think about working with Miles anyway. I wanted to work with Max Roach and Clifford Brown. Because remember when I came to New York, Booker Little and George Coleman was working with Max and they were getting ready to go to Philly so they didn't have no piano. Ray Draper and Art Davis. So I go into Max and started playing the piano kind of like to let them know I knew the music. And they said, "Yeah it sounds good but there is nothing happening here so we ain't using no piano. So Miles came down and I told Betty Carter that my closing, or her closing night would have been my opening night at the Black Hawk in San Francisco. And Benny Carter said, "I'm not going to let you out because if he wants you now he can wait a night." So as it turns out Victor Feldman did the opening night. So Miles came by to see me at Birdland and he listened and listened. And it's mainly because of the way I comp. The Prophet and Joe Griffith thought I would be good for Miles because I knew how to comp and stay out of his way. So I came off the bandstand and he would throw a punch at me [inaudible] he would throw a punch at me. That meant you were okay. You know, that meant I like what I'm hearing so he called me and told me where to pick up the tickets. Now I haven't said that — I was prepared to get to the gig and for him to say that he may have changed his mind because it wouldn't have surprised me because I knew

during that time he had been known to maybe do that, "I changed my mind." Because what he did, like on the "Seven Steps to Heaven" date, that was conceived when I was in the band on that tour. And we had a great time. Jimmy Cobb will tell you about it, Roy talks about it in the book. There was me, so he asked me, "Do you know a good alto player?" I said, "Yeah, Frank Strozier." He said, "What's Frank doin'?" Because he knew us from Chicago. So I told Frank to go by but Frank was reluctant. So his wife says, "No Frank, you should go," because George Coleman was already hired. Because Coltrane recommended George Coleman for the gig. And Ron Carter was going to be in the band, and Jimmy Cobb was just finishing up a tour so Tony Williams was going to join the band. And we had a great six weeks. Miles made every gig. And there were times when he'd tell me if I didn't play a certain note at a certain chord he was going to strand me, meaning like they would leave and leave me in a city by myself. But I didn't care, because I always kept me some bus money or some airfare, you know what I mean. He was teasing you know what I mean. But he told me, "You sure can swing." Well when he said I sure can swing that was a compliment coming behind Wynton Kelly, because there's nobody swinging harder than Wynton Kelly. So we had a great six weeks. He'd get to the gig at the Shelly's Manne Hole before time, "Let's play some music." You know he was a practical — he was always messing with you. He always supported me, even after I left the band he supported me. He had me on a regular standing, "You've really got your stuff together now." So during that time I was talking to Mulgrew that I didn't really understand modes. For some reason. I look at it now and I say it's easy to understand modes, you know [scats] with the voicing. So Mulgrew says, "Hey man, a whole lot of piano players didn't understand modes at that time. You know it seems so simple now, just the basic idea of how you're supposed to do it with clusters of stuff. But then, man, it was foreign to me. But so yeah, that was from April 1 until about April 24, man. He said, "I've got a gig for you." So I went and worked with Sonny Rollins at Birdland for a week and then after that I joined J.J. Johnson's band.

MR: Wow. I envy your experiences.

HM: Yeah. As you say, I've been around the block a few times.

MR: Well just to wrap up, I can tell that you're proud to be a jazz musician, and you're proud of your fellow jazz musicians.

HM: Right.

MR: I mean you were saying yesterday that jazz musicians are some of the most intelligent, well rounded people.

HM: Right. They really are. Because like I said any subject matter you name, any one, anything, they're doing it somewhere. Ophthalmology, they're doing it. Optometry? Speak a different language? They're doing it. Herbie Hancock, electrical engineer,

because I remember once he was talking because Oscar Peterson had a tremendous respect for Herbie. He said it in print. And he was talking about it one time. I got this video called "In the Key of Oscar." This is a very good video. I don't know if you can get it in the States, you might have to call the Institute of Canada in Toronto and get it. Mulgrew has it, and it's Oscar doing a reunion with his family members because he had been estranged from a couple of his kids because he was so busy traveling and they couldn't understand I can't be here with you because I'm trying to go out here to make this money so I can send you to the kind of —. You know what I mean. But they had to come and get him. And Oscar was talking about a lot of stuff and like he said, "No, I don't want to intimidate nobody, he said, but if you get in my way I'm going to run over you musically." And he cleared that up. You know what I'm saying. But he was talking about Herbie Hancock. Herbie said, "Well you know about the electric piano." And Herbie said, "Well you know, Oscar, I think Oscar is scared of the electric piano." Oscar: "you tell Herbie Hancock he better hope and pray that I don't come out." Because Oscar knew a lot about the electric piano because in his studio he had every electrical instrument he could. But, "I don't want to do an electric piano date for the sake of doing it." He said, "I can do three trio dates in one day in less than three hours." But he said, "No Herbie's been baiting me on to do it, but he has tremendous respect for Herbie. You know what I mean. But I feel good that I've had a chance to be around some great people. I wish I could have been around Art Tatum. I never saw Art Tatum in person. I never saw my other hero Nat Cole in person. I did see Bird but not up close and personal. I did see him standing outside the club. So I feel I've been blessed because as I said before, musicians are, man, wide range. Jimmy Heath, computer; Frank Foster, computer; Ben Brown, computer; Dr. Denny Zeitlin, practicing psychiatrist; Dr. Art Davis, psychiatrist; Peter LaRoca, attorney at law. The list just goes on and on. Sir Charles Thompson could be a golf pro; Joe Williams, golf; Lou Donaldson, Jimmy Cobb, Keter Betts, Freddie Green, Ray Brown, mean with the stick. Ray Brown, heck of a businessman. You know, Hubert Laws, go out and do concerts with Jean Pierre Rampal played that stuff, and they couldn't play here. Hubert Laws, you know, that flute. You know Jesus, Julius Baker I think was principal flautist with the Philharmonic. So jazz musicians, Herbie just did a George Gershwin classical Chopin type concert with a Chinese piano player named Lang Lang. And Herbie took off five months and got a teacher just to mainly deal with certain fingerings. But he practiced diligent and Garnett Brown, another one of my home towners, great trombone player, unsung hero, his name is Garnett Brown. He did some orchestrations for Herbie. He did the soundtrack for a movie called "Harlem Nights" with Richard Pryor. He wrote the music for that. He went to school with Reggie Miller's father in Memphis, Tennessee, Sard Miller, but he never gets any credit but he's a

tremendous, we call him Tut, King Tut, and he's like number one in California. He knows a lot about the college game. He's always renting TVs and videos and stuff. But Herbie did this classical type thing with Lang Lang this [inaudible] series thing. It was overwhelming. Because Herbie, well he was a Mozart major. But anything he puts his mind to do when he's going to do it, he's going to do it extremely well. That's why I say you know what I told you, Keith Jarrett did the Goldberg Variations and the classical musicians said wow, gee whiz. Ahmad Jamal was playing Lizst etudes when he was eleven years old with the Pittsburgh Symphony Orchestra. He never talks about it. So the list goes on and on and on you know.

MR: Yeah. And you seem to have found a good partner working relationship with Eric Alexander.

HM: Oh yeah. Oh yeah.

MR: That's great to see.

HM: I can't say enough about him. He's so phenomenal and he gets better and he's so smart. Expert skier. He ran the Chicago marathon a few years ago just to do it, and out of 27,000 he finished in the top 600 and the winning time was 2 hours and 8 minutes and Eric's finishing time was 2 hours and 50 minutes. Do you believe that? Long distance runner. When we go to Japan, he'll run two hours before the gig. You know? So I have tremendous respect for him because first of all you've got to be in some kind of physical shape to play this music. Now if you're just sitting up there, talking about cocktail china, that's okay, well you just play. But if you're talking about hard core swinging hard stamina, and as a piano player I've got to play three to four to five choruses behind these players, I've got to be physically in shape. You know what I'm saying. So I feel very blessed that the Creator bestowed this little bit of talent on me so since I got it, I just try to pursue it more and get better. Because every day you learn something. It's something you put in your sack of surprises, musically speaking, or whatever. Because you need your bag of tricks because when some of the guys come around, they're coming to hear some of them, the piano players. I remember one time I played at a place called Bradley's. It might have been a one night gig. Ten piano players came. Sir Roland Hanna, Jackie Byard now that's another unsung hero he was, Jackie Byard man, oh, what a tremendous musician. But he never got his total recognition. George Coleman never got his total recognition that he deserved. And the most underrated, unappreciated musician of all time is Phineas Newborn Junior. And to this day I don't understand that. Maybe it's jealousy. It's like how dare you to be that good? Here's a man that could put his right hand in his pocket and play complete competition with his right hand. There's a record called "Will of the Piano." I bought it up here with me, that every piano player should have. So Hank Jones once said, "I'm trying to figure out what it is about Phineas. He has

two right hands." Tommy Flanagan loved him. Ahmad Jamal loved him. But they really dogged him, just to tell you the truth, that you know, and hopefully one day, I don't know how, something can be done. Because he should be alive and well but he was heartbroken you see. So if you're not tough-skinned out there, between the system and some of the critics and some of the musicians, and you can listen to what they said and believe it, hey may you'll go under. But I refuse to let them to that to me. I say, "Well thank you very much, you're entitled to your opinion." Because I'm not saying anybody's got to be a Harold Mabern fan, you know, so I just do what I do and if I'm honest, and if I'm okay with it most of the time, and if I'm not okay with you then it's your problem, you know. I'm not perfect but I'm pure of heart. And that's the philosophy that I live by. You know what I'm saying.

MR: Well it's a good one, and I have learned some nice surprises from you in the last few days.

HM: Well I hope it's something that can be beneficial.

MR: Yeah. I want to thank you for your time today.

HM: Thank you.

MR: I look forward to your concert tonight.

HM: Thank you Mr. Monk Rowe, well my pleasure.